

D016

Leadership Foundations and Ethics

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A leadership team at a newly consolidated middle school with a large sports program drafts this line: "Our school provides every student a rigorous, supportive education that prepares them for high school." The team meets in the library every Tuesday. What kind of statement is this?

- A. A SMART goal.
- B. A core value.
- C. A vision statement.
- D. A mission statement.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A principal wants to write the school's vision statement. Which sentence fits?

- A. "We educate students in grades 6–8 through a rigorous curriculum."
- B. "Respect, integrity, perseverance."
- C. "Raise eighth-grade math proficiency by 10 points by June."
- D. "A community where every graduate leaves ready for college, career and citizenship."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A principal who holds a doctorate in leadership and has a strong writing background plans to revise the school's vision. Staff turnover is high and families rarely attend events. What process will most likely build real commitment?

- A. Adopt the district's vision word for word.
- B. Write it personally, since the principal is the strongest writer, and present it at the next staff meeting.
- C. Lead a series of sessions where staff, students, families and community members help draft and refine the vision.
- D. Wait until families attend more events, since input is never useful from a small group.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

At a school with a new playground and a strong parent association, the principal shares a compelling picture of what students could achieve, coaches teachers to take on new roles, and invites them to shape the plan. Which leadership approach is this?

- A. Transformational leadership.
- B. Managerial leadership, because the school has good facilities.
- C. Laissez-faire leadership.
- D. Transactional leadership.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A principal tells staff that anyone who submits lesson plans on time every week will get first pick of duty schedules; late plans lead to a meeting. Which approach is this?

- A. Servant leadership, because it helps staff get good schedules.
- B. Transformational leadership.
- C. Transactional leadership.
- D. Distributed leadership.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A first-year principal in a building with an aging heating system finds that most of her day goes to facilities calls, lunch duty and email. Reading scores are flat, and she has visited few classrooms. The district just approved a new bus contract. What should she change first?

- A. Schedule regular classroom visits with feedback, and delegate routine operations where possible.
- B. Review the new bus contract.
- C. Spend more time on the heating system so classrooms are comfortable.
- D. Buy a new reading program without visiting classrooms.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A principal says she practices distributed leadership. At a school known for its award-winning band, she assigns teachers to copy handouts, supervise hallways and set up assemblies, while she makes all curriculum decisions herself. What is the problem?

- A. Nothing; any sharing of work is distributed leadership.
- B. She should give the band director more decisions.
- C. This is task delegation; distributed leadership shares real influence over decisions with teacher leaders.
- D. She should stop delegating altogether.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

Six weeks into a new writing workshop model, which the staff chose after visiting a school two states away, teachers report feeling less confident and early writing scores dipped slightly. The visit was paid for by a grant. What should the leader do?

- A. Drop the model, because the scores prove it does not work.
- B. Ignore the concern, since changes always improve results.
- C. Ask the grant funder whether to continue.
- D. Recognize the implementation dip, add coaching and collaboration time, and keep monitoring rather than abandoning the model.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A principal is planning a major change to grading practices. Knowing about the implementation dip, what should she plan before launch?

- A. Promise staff the change will improve results immediately.
- B. Tell staff to expect an early rough patch and schedule support and check-ins for the first months.
- C. Launch without a plan, since dips cannot be managed.
- D. Plan to evaluate and decide in the first two weeks.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

At a staff meeting in the recently repainted cafeteria, a principal prepares to share state test results showing large gaps between student groups. Several board members plan to attend. How should the data be presented to build community and improve culture?

- A.** Hide the gaps until the board members leave.
- B.** Share the school-wide and group results openly and have teams explore possible causes and next steps together.
- C.** Rank teachers by their students' scores on a slide.
- D.** Share only the highest scores to keep morale up.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A well-liked principal at a school with high community support is asked by an influential parent, who donates generously each year, to change her child's course grade so the child can make the honor roll. The teacher's grade followed the published policy. What should the principal do?

- A.** Decline, explain the grading policy and appeal process, and treat the family as any other.
- B.** Change the grade, because the family supports the school.
- C.** Tell the teacher to decide alone and stay out of it entirely.
- D.** Change it quietly, since good intentions make it acceptable.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A principal's sibling owns a company bidding to supply the school's new laptops. What is the ethical action?

- A.** Keep quiet, since the principal knows the company is good.
- B.** Disclose the relationship and step out of the selection decision.
- C.** Choose the sibling's company if its price is lowest.
- D.** Reject the sibling's bid automatically in every case.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A leadership team at a newly consolidated middle school ~~with a large sports program~~ drafts this line: "Our school provides every student a rigorous, supportive education that prepares them for high school." ~~The team meets in the library every Tuesday.~~ What kind of statement is this?

Target word: classify the statement **Decides:** It states current purpose and whom it serves.

A	Adjacent category	It has no measurable target or deadline.
B	Confusion set	Values are guiding beliefs such as integrity or equity.
C	Confusion set	A vision describes a desired future state.
D	Correct	It describes what the school does now and for whom.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

A principal wants to write the school's vision statement. Which sentence fits?

Target word: pick the vision **Decides:** A vision pictures the future the school is working toward.

A	Inverted operation	Current purpose: a mission.
B	Confusion set	These are core values.
C	Adjacent category	A measurable goal, not a vision.
D	Correct	Describes the desired future.

3. Answer C Concept 2

A principal ~~who holds a doctorate in leadership and has a strong writing background~~ plans to revise the school's vision. Staff turnover is high and families rarely attend events. What process will most likely build real commitment?

Target word: process for revising the vision **Decides:** Shared development builds ownership.

A	Adjacent category	Alignment matters, but copying skips the school community.
B	Camouflage	Answers the writing skill, skipping shared ownership.
C	Correct	People commit to what they help create.
D	Absolute language	Leaders reach out to gather input; they do not wait.

4. Answer A Concept 3

At a school ~~with a new playground and a strong parent association~~, the principal shares a compelling picture of what students could achieve, coaches teachers to take on new roles, and invites them to shape the plan. Which leadership approach is this?

Target word: name the approach **Decides:** Inspiring shared vision and building capacity.

A	Correct	Inspires commitment to a shared vision and develops people.
B	Camouflage	Facilities do not define the approach.
C	Confusion set	Laissez-faire is hands-off; this leader is highly engaged.
D	Inverted operation	Transactional leadership centers on exchanges of rewards and consequences.

5. Answer C Concept 3 · transfer

A principal tells staff that anyone who submits lesson plans on time every week will get first pick of duty schedules; late plans lead to a meeting. Which approach is this?

Target word: name the approach **Decides:** A clear exchange of reward and consequence for compliance.

A	Confusion set	Servant leadership puts others' growth first, not rewards for compliance.
B	Inverted operation	No inspiration or capacity-building is involved.
C	Correct	Rewards and consequences tied to meeting a standard.
D	Adjacent category	No decision-making is shared.

6. Answer A Concept 4

A first-year principal in a building ~~with an aging heating system~~ finds that most of her day goes to facilities calls, lunch duty and email. Reading scores are flat, and she has visited few classrooms. ~~The district just approved a new bus contract.~~ What should she change first?

Target word: priority change **Decides:** Protect time for teaching and learning.

A	Correct	Instructional leadership keeps the focus on instruction.
B	Camouflage	An operational item that does not address flat scores.
C	Camouflage	Answers the facilities detail, not the instruction gap.
D	Dropped element	Skips observing current instruction.

7. Answer C Concept 5

A principal says she practices distributed leadership. ~~At a school known for its award-winning band,~~ she assigns teachers to copy handouts, supervise hallways and set up assemblies, while she makes all curriculum decisions herself. What is the problem?

Target word: what is wrong **Decides:** Only tasks are handed off; no decision-making is shared.

A	Absolute language	Chores are not leadership.
B	Camouflage	Answers the band detail, not the leadership model.
C	Correct	The core of distributed leadership is shared authority.
D	Inverted operation	The fix is to share decisions, not to remove all delegation.

8. Answer D Concept 6

Six weeks into a new writing workshop model, which the staff chose ~~after visiting a school two states away,~~ teachers report feeling less confident and early writing scores dipped slightly. ~~The visit was paid for by a grant.~~ What should the leader do?

Target word: response to early decline **Decides:** An early dip is expected in real change.

A	Inverted operation	Reads the expected dip as failure.
B	Absolute language	Leaders must still support staff and monitor data.
C	Camouflage	The funder does not decide how to lead the change.
D	Correct	Support through the dip lets the change take hold.

9. Answer B Concept 6 · transfer

A principal is planning a major change to grading practices. Knowing about the implementation dip, what should she plan before launch?

Target word: plan ahead for the dip **Decides:** Expect and prepare for an early drop.

A	Absolute language	Sets up disappointment when the dip comes.
B	Correct	Preparing people for the dip keeps commitment through it.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out the support that helps staff through it.
D	Inverted operation	Judging too early catches the dip, not the result.

10. Answer B Concept 7

At a staff meeting ~~in the recently repainted cafeteria~~, a principal prepares to share state test results showing large gaps between student groups. ~~Several board members plan to attend.~~ How should the data be presented to build community and improve culture?

Target word: how to present data **Decides:** Use data to ask shared questions, not to blame.

A	Camouflage	Answers the board detail; concealing data undermines trust.
B	Correct	Shared inquiry builds trust and ownership.
C	Inverted operation	Public ranking breeds blame and fear.
D	Dropped element	Leaves out the gaps that need action.

11. Answer A Concept 8

A ~~well-liked principal at a school with high community support~~ is asked by an influential parent, who donates generously each year, to change her child's course grade so the child can make the honor roll. The teacher's grade followed the published policy. What should the principal do?

Target word: ethical response **Decides:** The grade followed policy; changing it for a donor is unethical.

A	Correct	Fairness and professional ethics apply equally to all families.
B	Camouflage	Donations do not justify favoritism.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out the leader's duty to uphold policy and model ethics.
D	Adjacent category	Intent does not override the ethical duty of fairness.

12. Answer B Concept 8 · transfer

A principal's sibling owns a company bidding to supply the school's new laptops. What is the ethical action?

Target word: response to a conflict of interest **Decides:** A personal financial tie to a bidder is a conflict of interest.

A	Inverted operation	Hiding the tie is the core ethical failure.
B	Correct	Disclosure and recusal protect the fairness of the process.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out disclosure and recusal.
D	Absolute language	The fix is disclosure and recusal, not automatic exclusion.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	5	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	5	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	8	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Mission, vision and core values	The mission states the school's purpose and whom it serves now; the vision describes the future it is working toward; core values are the beliefs that guide how people act along the way.	Writing a future aspiration and calling it the mission, or listing goals as values.	Present purpose vs. future picture vs. guiding beliefs.
2	Shared development builds ownership	Mission, vision and values gain commitment when faculty, staff, students, families and community help create them.	A leader drafting the statements alone and presenting them for approval.	A question about how to create or revise guiding statements.
3	Transformational vs. transactional leadership	Transformational leaders inspire commitment to a shared vision and build people's capacity; transactional leaders manage through clear exchanges of rewards and consequences for meeting standards.	Treating rewards-for-compliance as transformational.	Inspiration and growth vs. exchange and compliance.
4	Instructional leadership	An instructional leader keeps the focus on teaching and learning: frequent classroom visits, feedback on practice, curriculum alignment, and protected time for collaboration.	Letting building management fill the day while instruction goes unobserved.	A choice about how the leader spends limited time.
5	Distributed leadership	Distributed leadership shares real decision-making and influence with teacher leaders and teams, building capacity beyond the principal.	Calling the handing off of chores "distributed leadership."	Whether others gain authority over decisions or only receive tasks.
6	The implementation dip	Performance and confidence often drop early in a real change; leaders should expect it, provide support and hold course rather than abandon the change.	Reading the early dip as proof the change failed.	Early results worse than before, shortly after a new initiative.
7	Data to build shared ownership, not blame	Share data openly and use it to ask questions together, so it builds trust, shared urgency and a culture of continuous improvement.	Using data publicly to single out or rank individual teachers.	How results are presented to staff or community.
8	Modeling ethical behavior	Leaders follow professional ethical codes, act with fairness and transparency, avoid conflicts of interest, and put students' interests first, even under pressure.	Bending rules for a powerful stakeholder because the intent seems good.	Pressure, a personal relationship, or a shortcut that benefits one party.

Course scope (public description): Leadership Foundations and Ethics presents candidates with a variety of leadership theories and strategies used by PK-12 educational leaders to develop, sustain, and evaluate a coherent system of academic and social supports that meet the full range of students' needs. Foundational knowledge addresses the importance of developing mission, vision, and core values in collaboration with faculty, staff, and the school community to advocate for student success. The course also covers communication strategies, interpersonal skills, and using data to build community, influence school culture, and manage change for continuous improvement. In addition, candidates are introduced to the significance of following professional ethical codes and the importance of modeling and advocating ethical behavior with all stakeholders.